interiors. The Indus and the Ganga are the only two Indian rivers marked but their courses are essentially arbitrary. It also shows the Malay peninsula and marks Melaka (spelled *Malacha* on the map). A well-known map by Waldseemüller in 1513 has a broadly similar layout. Over the next century, more maps were published and the level of knowledge improved, albeit not always linearly. Mistakes were common and often perpetuated by cartographers copying information from each other. Empty spaces were decorated with drawings, often echoing the fantastical creatures of Mandeville. Nonetheless, geographical knowledge went through a major shift in the sixteenth century. At the centre of the cartographic revolution were two individuals, Gerardus Mercator and Abraham Ortilius, contemporaries from the Low Countries.

Mercator was born in 1512 near Antwerp and was an accomplished engraver of maps and charts by the time he was twenty-four. Although he does not seem to have ever travelled to the faraway lands that were being newly discovered, he was able to systematically assimilate all the information available about them. In 1538, he published his first world map that is one of the earliest to bear the names North and South America. He also showed Asia and America to be separate continents long before the discovery of the Bering Strait proved it to be a fact.

Mercator lived in a time of great religious and political ferment. An innovator who asked too many questions was always suspect and, in 1544, he was arrested as a heretic. If he had not been rescued by influential friends a few months later, it is likely that he would have been beheaded or burned at the stake by the Inquisition. A few years later, Mercator would shift east to Duisburg where he would produce his most famous work. In 1569, he produced his world map with the legend ‘New and Improved Description of the Lands of the World, amended and intended for the use of Navigators’[11]. The map did not just have richer information than earlier maps; it used a novel system of projecting the curved surface of the world on a flat surface. This was a major innovation in cartography. The ‘Mercator Projection’ is still the most commonly used format for a world map even though it is based on a distortion that squeezes the countries near